

AI-POWERED PM WORKFLOW · SECTION FRAMEWORK

WorkPass AI

Instant, AI-native worker verification & onboarding for Australia's high-risk industries

Research & Ideate — Workflows 1 & 2

Prepared as a working brief and a foundation for the Latitude 37 (by Airwallex) application.

How to read this document

This brief follows Section's **AI-Powered PM Workflow**. It documents **Workflow 1: Research** (competitive & market research, best practices, target segments) and **Workflow 2: Ideate** (user journey, diversity of thought, short/long-term balance). The final section maps everything to the **Latitude 37 application criteria**.

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Executive Summary

The product. WorkPass AI is an AI-native platform that verifies and onboards high-volume, blue-collar workers in minutes instead of days. A worker uploads their ID, tickets (White Card, High Risk Work Licences), and background documents; the AI checks authenticity, flags fraud, validates the credential against the issuing body, and approves the profile — then tracks expiries automatically to keep the employer compliant with Work Health and Safety (WHS) law.

Why now. Australia's resource and construction sectors are absorbing a wave of inexperienced workers to fill a structural labour gap. The mining sector alone needs over 8,000 extra workers by 2026, and construction faces a projected 300,000-worker shortfall by 2027. Every one of those new starters needs document and credential verification before they can legally step on site — a manual bottleneck that costs employers time, money, and lost production every single day.

The founder edge. I lived this exact bottleneck running courier onboarding at DiDi in Latin America, where manual profile approval — document review, photo checks, background screening — was the single biggest brake on growth. I am now applying that operational scar tissue to Australia's high-risk industries, with a network of mining-industry contacts to seed the first pilots.

One-line pitch

“I lived the bottleneck of manually approving thousands of worker profiles at DiDi in LatAm. Australian mining and construction now face the same problem at scale because of the talent shortage — I'm building the AI that approves a worker in minutes, not days, while keeping employers WHS-compliant.”

Workflow 1 — Research

Section's first workflow is about replacing weeks of manual market scanning with a fast, multi-source, AI-assisted snapshot. This section covers the three Research use cases: **competitive & market research**, **best practices & examples**, and **target user segment profiles**. Throughout, the “devil's advocate” technique from the workshop is used to pressure-test the idea.

Use Case 1 — Competitive & Market Research

The problem, quantified

The labour shortage is the engine that creates the onboarding problem. As employers drop the “experience required” filter, they pull in backpackers, career-changers, and international workers — all of whom arrive with documents to verify and no employment history on file.

- **Mining:** the sector needs ~8,000 additional workers by 2026; forecasts show only 16,000 available against 24,400 required.
- **Construction:** employs ~1.3 million people (~9% of the national workforce) and faces a projected 300,000-worker shortfall by 2027.
- **FIFO scale:** over 100,000 workers participate in fly-in-fly-out roles, concentrated in WA and QLD mining regions — a constant, high-churn onboarding pipeline.

Why verification is the acute pain

Ticket and licence compliance — White Card, High Risk Work Licences, trade qualifications, EWP and forklift cards — is repeatedly described as the single highest-stakes area of workforce admin. The legal exposure makes it non-optional: under WHS legislation, an employer must verify proof of a valid White Card before a worker starts, record the details and expiry, and failing to do so can trigger regulatory action. “No card, no entry” is the operating rule on every high-risk site.

Competitive landscape

The space is not empty — but the incumbents are heavy, configuration-led compliance platforms rather than fast, AI-native approval tools. There are three clusters:

Cluster	Who / what they do	The gap they leave
Enterprise compliance platforms	Damstra (now Ideagen Workforce Safety), INX, ComplyFlow — contractor onboarding, credential tracking, site access. ~1.5M+ workers managed on Damstra; ComplyFlow serves 6,000+ users across mining, logistics, property.	Modular, setup-heavy, priced per worker/year. Built for corporate risk officers, not for instant, mobile-first approval at high churn.
Identity / background-check engines	Checkr, Onfido — ML + biometrics for document authentication and fraud; First Advantage, Sterling, Vetty for gig background checks.	Horizontal and US/EU-centric. They verify identity but do not own the Australian ticket/WHS workflow or expiry compliance.

Cluster	Who / what they do	The gap they leave
All-in-one HRIS	Worknice, ELMO, foundU, Humanforce — multi-entity HR, rostering, payroll with onboarding bolted on.	Onboarding is a feature, not the product. Verification depth and speed are shallow.

Honest note on the moving target: ComplyFlow already markets an “AI safety agent” and real-time document checks that it claims cut admin by 70%. This means “we add AI” is not, by itself, a defensible wedge — the differentiation has to be speed, worker-side experience, and depth in the Australian ticket ecosystem, not the mere presence of AI. This is addressed directly in Use Case 2 and in the Ideate section.

Devil's Advocate — “Convince me NOT to build this”

- 1. Crowded and capitalised:** Onfido, Checkr and Deel have hundreds of millions in funding; ComplyFlow and Damstra own the Australian relationships. A head-on fight is suicide.
- 2. Incumbent feature-creep:** the closest competitor is already shipping AI document checks. The window to differentiate on “instant approval” may be narrow.
- 3. Enterprise sales cycles:** large miners and tier-1 builders procure slowly; a 25-year-old solo founder must prove credibility and security fast.

These objections are real and shape the strategy: enter through a sharp, under-served wedge (see below) rather than competing as another full compliance suite.

Use Case 2 — Best Practices & Examples

Section's prompt asks for differentiation inspired by startups that won against large incumbents in crowded markets. Three plays apply directly to WorkPass AI:

Play 1 — Win on the “approval moment,” not the whole suite

The incumbents sell a platform you configure. The wedge is the painful, repeated micro-moment: a new worker's profile sitting in a queue waiting for a human to eyeball a licence. Owning that one moment — upload to approved in minutes — is a sharper promise than “manage all your compliance.” This mirrors how vertical AI tools win: take one high-frequency, high-friction task and make it instant.

Play 2 — Vertical depth in the Australian ticket ecosystem

A thin AI wrapper around generic document upload is easy to copy. Defensibility comes from deeply modelling Australian credentials — White Card formats by state, High Risk Work Licence classes, EWP/forklift tickets, RTO validity, state-by-state WHS nuances — and validating against issuing bodies. That sector-specific compliance depth is a recognised defensibility vector when incumbents are stretched and slow.

Play 3 — Be a partner, not a rip-and-replace

The cautionary tale: a thin wrapper dies if the incumbent can bundle it into a platform the customer already pays for. The most durable opportunities are deep vertical workflows and compliance tools that act as a valued partner. Practically, WorkPass AI should integrate with the HRIS/payroll systems

employers already run (rather than trying to replace them on day one), and own the verification layer beneath them.

Long-term moat

Build the wedge → integrate selectively with the systems of record → expand modules → accumulate a proprietary dataset of verified worker credentials and fraud patterns that makes the incumbent's manual process obsolete. This is a multi-year journey, but each verified worker deepens the data moat.

Use Case 3 — Target User Segment Profiles

Two segments, profiled with TAM signal, characteristics, and value drivers, plus an anti-persona.

Primary segment — Labour-hire & contractor firms supplying mining/construction

Who	Labour-hire agencies and contractor companies that onboard large, rotating pools of workers for high-risk sites.
Why them first	They feel the pain most acutely: highest churn, thinnest margins, and they carry the WHS liability if a worker steps on site with an invalid ticket. Speed-to-deploy is literally revenue.
Value drivers	Time-to-activate a worker; fewer rejected/abandoned applicants; audit-proof compliance records; fraud detection on fake tickets.
TAM signal	100,000+ FIFO workers and a 300k construction shortfall mean millions of onboarding/verification events per year, each one a billable transaction.
GTM motion	Founder-led, warm-intro sales through the mining network; land one labour-hire firm, prove time saved, expand by referral.

Secondary segment — Mid-market mining & construction operators

Who	Operators with 200–2,000 staff running their own onboarding, often across multiple legal entities.
Why second	Bigger contracts and stickier, but slower procurement and more likely to already run an incumbent. Better as a land-and-expand target once the labour-hire wedge is proven.
Value drivers	Single source of truth for credentials; automated expiry tracking; reduced WHS regulatory exposure.
GTM motion	Integration-led; sit beneath their existing HRIS as the verification layer rather than replacing it.

Anti-persona (who we do NOT build for, yet)

- **White-collar / tech recruitment** (already saturated — Tamently, LinkedIn, Workday).

- **Low-risk industries** with no statutory ticket requirement — the WHS legal driver is what forces spend.
- **One-country US/EU gig platforms** — the initial edge is Australian ticket depth, not generic global ID.

Workflow 2 — Ideate

Section's second workflow turns research into human-centred design. This section covers the three Ideate use cases: **create the user journey**, **increase diversity of thought**, and **balance short- and long-term sustainability**.

Use Case 1 — Create the User Journey

Two Day-1 journeys were considered. Both start from the trigger that brings the customer in. Option A is the chosen path; Option B is the contrast.

Option A (chosen) — The labour-hire coordinator clears the morning queue

- 1. Trigger:** It's 7am. A coordinator has 40 new workers who must be site-ready for a Monday mining roster. Normally this is a full day of manually opening PDFs, squinting at White Cards, and chasing missing documents.
- 2. First value:** They forward the batch of worker uploads into WorkPass AI. Within minutes, each profile returns a status — approved, flagged (with the exact reason: blurry photo, expired ticket, name mismatch), or fraud-suspected.
- 3. The “aha”:** The coordinator sees 32 auto-approved and 8 flagged with precise fixes — a full day's work compressed into one coffee.
- 4. Reason to return:** WorkPass AI sets automatic expiry reminders for every approved worker, so the coordinator comes back not just to onboard, but to stay compliant — turning a one-off tool into daily infrastructure.

Option B (contrast) — Worker self-service portal

Workers upload their own documents and get an instant readiness score before applying. Compelling for worker experience, but it sells to the wrong buyer first (the worker, who doesn't pay) and is slower to monetise. Verdict: keep as a later feature that feeds Option A, not the Day-1 wedge.

Why Option A wins

It targets the buyer who feels the pain and holds the budget (and the WHS liability), delivers visible value in the first session, and builds a recurring reason to return (expiry tracking). It has the shape of the products that win: a daily, painful, internal workflow made instant.

Use Case 2 — Increase Diversity of Thought

Acting as a “radical product strategist,” here are unconventional angles to pressure-test the concept — each with the convention it breaks, the upside, and the risk.

Unconventional idea	Upside of breaking convention	Risk to watch
Verification as an API, not an app	Embed instant checks inside the HRIS/job boards employers already use; become the rails, not another login.	Harder to show a flashy demo; value is invisible infrastructure.

Unconventional idea	Upside of breaking convention	Risk to watch
Worker-owned, portable “work passport”	A worker verifies once and reuses across employers — strong network effect and a moat the incumbents lack.	Two-sided cold-start; privacy and consent design must be airtight.
Fraud-detection as the headline	Lead with catching fake tickets — a visceral safety and liability story for a regulator-watched industry.	Must be demonstrably accurate; false positives erode trust fast.
LatAm-first, Australia-anchored	Prove the engine where the founder has unfair access, then bring it to the Australian market.	Tension with Latitude 37's Australia focus — must be framed deliberately.
Compliance “score” as a free wedge	Give a free readiness check to acquire accounts, charge for batch + monitoring (the a16z “AI wedge” play).	Must convert free users; risk of commoditising the core check.

Note for the founder: the strongest combination is likely **API-embedded verification + fraud detection as the headline**, with the **portable work passport** as the long-term network-effect moat. Start with positioning and business model here, not feature lists.

Use Case 3 — Balance Short- and Long-Term Sustainability

A phased plan that drives early signups while investing in durable retention.

Short-term initiatives (drive signups / prove value)

- **Free “batch readiness check”:** a labour-hire firm uploads a batch and sees instant approve/flag results — zero-friction acquisition.
- **Founder-led pilots through the mining network:** 3–5 design partners who feel the pain daily (this is the Edexia playbook — traction before the program).
- **One sharp metric:** “time-to-activate a worker” before vs. after, captured per pilot for the application and future fundraising.

Long-term investments (retention / session depth)

- **Automatic expiry & re-verification monitoring:** turns onboarding into an always-on compliance subscription.
- **Proprietary fraud-pattern dataset:** every verified worker improves detection — a compounding moat.
- **Portable worker passport + HRIS integrations:** network effects and switching costs that incumbents can't easily replicate.

Phased plan

Phase 1 (0–3 mo): Free batch-check wedge + 3–5 mining/labour-hire pilots. Goal: prove time-to-activate.

Phase 2 (3–9 mo): Paid monitoring + expiry tracking; first HRIS integration. Goal: recurring revenue.

Phase 3 (9–18 mo): Portable work passport + fraud dataset; expand from labour-hire into mid-market operators.

Mapping to the Latitude 37 Application

Latitude 37 (by Airwallex) backs Australia-based AI founders aged 25 or under, with non-dilutive funding, mentorship, and global immersion. The program asks about your **big, bold idea**, the **strength and originality** of what you're building, and **what you understand about the AI space that others don't**. Here is how WorkPass AI answers each.

What Latitude 37 looks for	WorkPass AI's answer
Big, bold idea	Become the instant verification layer for every high-risk worker in Australia — and eventually a portable, worker-owned work passport across borders.
Originality / strength	Incumbents are heavy, configuration-led compliance suites for risk officers. WorkPass AI owns the single painful moment — upload to approved in minutes — with deep Australian ticket modelling and fraud detection.
What you know that others don't	I ran courier onboarding at DiDi in LatAm and lived the manual-approval bottleneck at scale. I know exactly where it breaks, why workers abandon, and how fraud slips through — knowledge you only get by operating it.
Australia fit	The wedge is built on White Card / High Risk Work Licence / WHS — wholly Australian. Brisbane-based, the same ecosystem that produced Edexia (YC W25).
Unfair access	A mining-industry network to seed pilots, plus a Generación del Bicentenario scholarship background and Australia–Peru ties (two global mining powers) for later expansion.

Action checklist before applying

- **Confirm eligibility:** verify you are based in Australia for the program duration (travel + cohort are in-person).
- **Get traction signal:** line up 2–3 “would-pay” conversations from the mining network — the Edexia lesson is traction beats polish.
- **Sharpen the metric:** define and capture “time-to-activate a worker” from the first pilot.
- **Frame the LatAm angle deliberately:** Australia-first wedge, LatAm as the founder's proof-ground and expansion path.

Next in the Section framework: Workflow 3 (Create) — prototype the batch-verification UI with mock data — and Workflow 4 (Collaborate). This document covers Research and Ideate only.